



Women wine consumers: information search and retailing implications

Women wine
consumers

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this research is to examine gender differences in information search procedures and selection criteria relative to purchase situation and social and financial risk aversion.

Design/methodology/approach – An online questionnaire was completed by 497 males and 877 females in the USA. A total of 88 percent of the respondents stated that they drank wine at least once per week. Participants were obtained by sending e-mails to customer lists provided by wine-related organizations.

Findings – Findings suggest that, if a consumer is unsure about making a wine selection, women are more apt than men to seek information from store personnel, a server, sommelier, or winery personnel. Labels and shelf tags are also significantly more important for women. While winery region is very important to both men and women, women rely on medals and awards more than men.

Research limitations/implications – Consumers who are not necessarily comfortable with using the internet would not have had an opportunity to participate in this study.

Practical implications – The differences by gender in the importance of and the usage of various information sources could help retailers prioritize their communication methods in US stores. Store personnel, servers, sommeliers, and winery personnel should be well-prepared to answer questions and make recommendations.

Originality/value – Women buy 80 percent of the wine sold in the USA. This study helps retailers understand their preferences and how to assist them more effectively in their purchase decisions.

Keywords Information searches, Retailing, Wines, Consumers, Gender

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

As the global wine industry grows more competitive, marketers are asking themselves how best to differentiate their brands to consumers in ways that are critical to success. Consumer perceptions of a wine's quality are important factors in the decision process, but with thousands of wines to choose from, how does a consumer select one wine over another? When evaluating how wine buyers make their decisions, it is probably wise to look for differences by demographic and psychographic variables. A starting point may be to look at differences by gender. According to Rappaport *et al.* (1993), men and women do in fact differ in terms of the relative importance they will place on pleasure, health, and convenience as it relates to food and beverage consumption. In a study



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involving print ads, Le Bel (2005), found that women were more sensitive to ads that conveyed the wine's sensory qualities, while the men were more influenced by ads that emphasized sex appeal. Le Bel recommended that marketers consider gender differences in their branding and communication programs. These results suggest that men and women may use different criteria when selecting a wine. This research seeks to determine if women do indeed have a different set of preferences than men when choosing a wine.

According to a study by the Wine Market Council, 60 percent of Americans who consume wine once or more a week are women, and women buy 80 percent of the wine sold in the US (Anon., 2005). To be more specific, 80 percent of the shoppers purchasing wine on the retail shelves are women and many of these purchases are in grocery and discount stores (Hunt, 2005). Joanne Yaccato, author of *The 80% Minority: Reaching the Real World of Women Consumers*, states in an article entitled "Through the gender lens" (Yaccato, 2003), that there is a definite shortage of market intelligence from the female perspective.

There are many reasons for such a difference postulated in the press and in trade articles. In addition to family responsibilities, many US women work outside their homes. These women typically average 60 to 70 hours or more each week between their job and home responsibilities. These women are self-confident and individualistic, concerned with convenience, knowledgeable and demanding consumers, and indifferent to small price differences among stores or merchandise (Berman and Evans, 1998). These women suffer from a "poverty of time" and often place a high value on goods or services that minimize time expenditures (Berman and Evans, 1998). However, the importance of the wine purchase, perhaps an informal occasion versus a formal occasion, may affect the amount of time spent making a decision and evaluating alternatives.

Many wineries are starting to develop products that appeal primarily to women, such as lighter, low-alcohol wines. Tracey Mason of Beringer Blass Wine Estates notes, "as wines are becoming so alcoholic, it is difficult to drink a glass of wine during the week, especially with women's busy lives and having kids". She states that sometimes "women would really like to have a glass of wine but might forego it because of the demands on their lifestyles" (Anon., 2005, p. 12). In addition to developing new wines tailored to women's tastes and busy lives, marketers also need to develop a better understanding of how women shop for wine. In other words, what types of information do they rely on in making their wine buying decisions? Chaney (2000) reported that in a sample of 109 UK consumers, the two highest ranked information sources were point of sale material and labels. Her research found that there was very little external search undertaken prior to entering the store. No information was provided on the gender of the consumers in the sample, but this type of information would be important for wine marketers to know about US women who are purchasing wine.

In order to achieve success with a new product innovation there is a need for a strong market orientation. A policy of innovating without paying attention to the needs of consumers is most likely to result in fewer successful new products (Calentone and di Benedetto, 1994). An understanding of what quality means to consumers offers the promise of improving brand positions through more precise market segmentation, product planning, promotion, and pricing strategy (Zeithaml, 1988). It is important to know which cues are important and how they vary in different buying situations.

The wine industry has entered a stage where just making good products is not enough to grow the market. There is a wide choice of products available for consumers and these industries need to move from a production orientation to a marketing orientation based upon understanding the consumer (Thomas, 2000). The consumer's choice is likely to be influenced to a greater extent by product attributes that are not part of the core product. Opportunities lie in designing extrinsic product attributes such as unique packaging (Orth, 2002).

The context in which the product is sold also affects how information reaches the consumer. More and more, it is the retailers that are the critical link in getting a brand into the hands of the consumer. As far as supermarket sales are concerned, up to 70 percent of consumer decisions are made in the store (Bramwell, 1997). The environment in which purchasing decisions are made is changing and this has created a gap in getting the word to consumers.

It is known that consumers use a variety of cues when making quality judgments. They consider price, the label, the brand, the region of origin, and shelf position (Jacoby and Olson, 1985; Lockshin *et al.*, 2006; Lockshin and Spawton, 2001). Many of the attributes are under the control of the producer so consumer response should be considered before implementing these attributes. An experiment providing information to some consumers and not others showed that knowledge of the purpose of alternative closures increased their acceptance (Murray and Lockshin, 1997), so there is some proof that point-of-sale information can help consumers adopt a discontinuous innovation. It is advantageous to isolate groups of potential customers who place differing emphasis on cues and to identify marketing opportunities by exploring the potential for cue combinations not currently available (Hair *et al.*, 1998).

In the academic literature, Spawton (1991a) contends that the major influences on wine purchase decisions are: perceived risk; product cues such as brand, label and price; product experience and knowledge; and the product-use situation. Fennell (1978) also found the product-use situation to be a critical factor in the purchase decision. Is the wine for consumption at home with family or for a dinner out with business associates? In other words, is there social or financial risk involved in the purchase? The purpose of this research is to examine the preferences for wine expressed by women in the US and compare them to the preferences expressed by men. Differences in information search, purchase situation, and coping mechanisms are also addressed.

Information search

A key factor in the successful marketing of wine to women in the retail setting will be the identification of what is important in the decision-making process. According to Perreault and McCarthy (2005), during the typical information search the consumer: determines the alternatives (in this case the various types of wine, varietals, and price ranges), and then, ascertains the characteristics of each wine alternative. The reader can immediately see a problem here because a busy woman will not have the time to ascertain the characteristics of thousands of wines. Actually, the extent to which a consumer searches for information depends, in part, on that individual's perception of the risk attached to the purchase. Risk varies among individuals and by the situation (Berman and Evans, 1998). Financial risk (an expensive bottle of wine) or social risk (an important business dinner) can raise the perceived risk involved in the purchase.

One of the retailer's roles in the consumer's search process is to provide enough information for the individual to feel comfortable in making wine purchase decisions, thereby reducing the wine purchaser's perceived risk. Point-of-purchase advertising (shelf-talkers), product displays (Harvest Fair Gold Medal Winners), and knowledgeable sales staff (not the produce manager) help provide wine purchasers with the information they need to make a decision.

In evaluating alternatives, a wine that is clearly superior to the others makes the consumer's decision quite easy. And a wine that is of excellent quality (a Gold Medal Winner) and has a low price (it is on sale) will be the easy choice over more expensive, average-quality wines. But most of the time evaluating the alternatives is not that easy. If two or more options seem attractive, then the buyer will have to determine which criteria (attributes) to evaluate and the relative importance of them. Then the wine alternatives will be ranked in the mind of the purchaser, and a decision will be made.

Purchase situation

Hall *et al.* (2001) examined the relationships between choice of wine and the type of dining occasion. In their survey of Australian wine consumers, they looked at two categories of attributes used when selecting a wine, explicit cues and implicit cues. Explicit cues consisted of familiarity, price, quality, taste, and suitability. The implicit cues used were color, packaging, country of origin, and the size of the container. The authors found that in all types of occasions, from intimate dinners to parties, price was the most important extrinsic cue. In the category of intrinsic cues, taste was the most important factor, with the type of wine (red or white) being next in importance. In the situations where respondents were dining with family members and/or friends, the desired consequences of the wine choice were to relax and socialize, enjoy a good complement to the food, and enjoy a decent quality wine. In the case of a party or celebration, the quality of the wine and socializing were still the highest desired outcomes, but impressing others gained significantly in importance. When a wine consumer starts talking about impressing others, social risk factors are involved in the decision-making.

Risk aversion

It appears that in certain wine consumption situations there is an element in the decision process that involves a risk-aversion strategy (Spawton, 1991b; Mitchell and Greatorex, 1989; Gluckman, 1990). Mitchell and Greatorex (1989) propose that purchasing wine mostly involves functional risks such as social risks, financial risks, and physical risks. Social risks may involve trying to avoid being embarrassed in front of business associates and friends; financial risks involve the cost of the wine, and physical risks involve the actual effects from alcohol consumption.

Spawton (1991b) identified six risk-reduction strategies used by wine consumers:

- (1) Selecting wine brands that represent consistent quality and are included in the range of "safe brands" established in the mind of the wine consumer.
- (2) Selecting wines based on the recommendations of friends and colleagues.
- (3) Following the advice of sales associates.
- (4) Using their own knowledge gained through wine education.
- (5) Price (as an indicator of quality).
- (6) Packaging and labeling as a indicator of quality.

Recent studies have also found that the origin of wine is often perceived as an indicator of quality and may be used as the basis of decision making when purchasing wine (Duhan *et al.*, 1999). Origin information typically serves as a halo from which inferences are made about unfamiliar wines. In the case of a US wine purchaser, the reputation of the Napa Valley can be used as an indicator of quality. Wines from other parts of the US have a difficult time competing with Napa's reputation. An international research project recently indicated that the most important attribute for both Australia and New Zealand was the geographic origin of wine (with local wines preferred over all other choices presented) and the most important attribute for the US was the type of wine (with red wine preferred over all other choices presented) (Atkin *et al.*, 2006).

In addition, medals, usually at the gold or silver level, have become a means of signaling quality to the wine purchaser. According to Ulrich Orth (2002), only a fraction of worldwide sales of wine go to sophisticated wine connoisseurs who are able to evaluate the quality of a wine based on varietal, producer, vintage, and vineyard. Orth contends that one method the average wine consumer relies on for signaling a quality wine is medals, usually at the gold or silver level. The paper stick-on medals help wine buyers quickly and reliably find quality wines on their retailers' shelves; however, Orth warns that consumers are becoming more savvy about medals and are aware that there are regional, national and international awards.

Research question

Based on the preceding discussion of wine buying behavior, we developed a set of research questions to ascertain gender differences in the wine purchasing situation. Do women's preferences differ from those of men? Specifically, do women's preferences on the following attributes of wine differ from those of men:

- Type of wine.
- Region of origin.
- Closure type.
- Price.
- Winery size?

Do women's information search behaviors differ from men's information search behaviors? Do women's coping mechanisms in the absence of information differ from those of men?

Data collection

The study sample represents only US wine drinkers and should not be taken as a general population sample. However, it is a reasonable sample to understand why some consumers prefer one wine style to another and the choice criteria and helping mechanisms they use to make their wine purchase decisions. The sample included 497 males and 877 females. Table I shows some significant differences by gender that will be discussed in the results section. The key demographic linked to these constructs was frequency of wine consumption. When asked how often they consumed wine, over 88 percent of respondents replied that they drank wine at least once per week. People who consume wine at least once a week are core drinkers, as defined by the Wine

Variable	Mean – men	SD men	Mean – women	SD women	t-value	Significance level
<i>Wine</i>						
Dry red	6.37	1.16	6.13	1.35	3.333	0.001
Aromatic white	4.75	1.62	4.68	1.72	0.752	0.452
Dry white	4.34	1.65	4.37	1.80	–0.366	0.714
Blush red	2.45	1.63	2.13	1.57	3.657	0.000
<i>Region</i>						
US	5.92	1.24	5.92	1.27	–0.054	0.957
Australia	5.14	1.30	5.29	1.31	–1.939	0.053
South America	4.51	1.33	4.82	1.34	–4.165	0.000
France	4.52	1.73	4.51	1.54	0.136	0.892
<i>Closure</i>						
Real cork	5.37	1.43	5.67	1.35	–3.955	0.000
Synthetic	4.17	1.55	4.08	1.53	1.107	0.268
Stelvin screw cap	3.97	1.75	3.20	1.79	7.875	0.000
<i>Price</i>						
Medium \$10.00 to \$14.99	5.43	1.40	5.82	1.20	–5.419	0.000
More – \$15.00 to \$24.99	5.30	1.28	5.21	1.33	1.223	0.221
Maximum – \$25.00 and up	4.37	1.78	3.90	1.66	4.959	0.000
Low – \$2.00 to \$9.99	4.14	1.96	4.34	1.94	–1.814	0.070
<i>Winery</i>						
Small	5.62	1.23	5.34	1.34	3.835	0.000
Regional	5.49	0.99	5.49	1.03	–0.049	0.961
National	4.38	1.30	4.55	1.31	–0.221	0.027
International	3.54	1.40	3.80	1.50	–3.226	0.001

Note: Based on a sample of 1,374 US wine drinkers: 497 males and 877 females

Table I.
Significant differences by
gender

Market Council (Thach, 2002). Our sample had very similar incidences of regular wine consumption (a few times weekly or more often) across both groups.

In cooperation with a Napa Valley-based closure manufacturer and a few US wineries interested in consumer preferences, we sought to determine the preferences of relatively frequent purchasers of wine (see preceding paragraph) in the US. We thought that consumers who appeared on various retailer or wine club mailing lists would be more likely to have developed well-formed opinions, being regular wine drinkers, and would provide the best indication of why or why not they purchased certain wines. One of the goals of the study was to examine the preferences of female consumers to see if their preferences differed from male consumers. Respondents were obtained in the US by sending e-mails to the customer lists provided by wine-related groups such as the Wine Brats and the Winex Wine Club. The Wine Brats are a non-profit group of young-at-heart wine enthusiasts who want to learn more about wine and meet regularly to discuss wine. The Winex Wine Club is a group formed by *Wine X Magazine*, a young adult lifestyle magazine featuring wine articles. The survey was

posted on the internet from June 15, 2004 to November 14, 2004. There were 1,691 respondents from the US.

Research was conducted by designing a web-based survey regarding various wine features. The specific questions were pre-tested with 50 respondents in the US. We collected empirical data by administering a survey in order to understand consumers buying preferences for a variety of wine attributes. Respondents used a seven-point scale to rate the following attributes:

- Type of wine: dry white, aromatic white, dry red, blush red.
- Region of origin of wine: Australia/New Zealand, France, Sonoma/Napa, Chile/Argentina.
- Closure type: traditional cork, synthetic cork, screw cap.
- Price: \$2.00 to \$9.99; \$10.00 to \$19.99; \$20.00 to 24.99; \$25.00 and up.
- Winery size: small boutique, mid-size region winery, large nationally recognized winery, international conglomerate winery.

Additional questions delved into the nature and extent of information search undertaken by respondents and the coping mechanisms used in conditions of uncertainty. For example one question related to information search and asked “when I am unsure about making a wine selection I . . .” This question was followed with nine statements. The respondent could respond by indicating on a seven-point scale the degree to which they agreed with each statement. A “1” indicated “strongly disagree” and “7” indicated “strongly agree”. The statements were: look at the bottle label, read the store shelf tags, look for newspaper or magazine reviews/recommendations, read books on wine, ask friends or family, consult the restaurant menu recommendations, consult with store personnel, consult with restaurant/winery personnel (server, sommelier), and other.

The second statement asked about choice criteria or decision coping mechanisms when “unsure about making a wine selection”. Table II provides a listing of the two categories of questions and the responses. Respondents completing the survey were entered into a lottery to win a case of wine worth \$100.

Results

The data for the US was split into two groups based on gender. An independent sample t-test of the means was then performed on key variables to determine if there was indeed a difference in preferences between men and women. Results are shown in Tables I and II.

We first addressed the difference in preference for basic types of wine. Both genders ranked the types of wine in the same order with dry red wines ranking the highest and blush red ranking the lowest. Although both showed the greatest preference for dry reds, the mean for men was significantly higher than the mean for women (mean – men = 6.37, SD = 1.16, mean – women = 6.13, SD = 1.35, $p = 0.001$). Men also showed a stronger preference for blush reds (mean – men = 2.45, SD = 1.63, mean – women = 2.13, SD = 1.57, $p = 0.000$). There was no significant difference on the white wines.

As far as the region of origin, US consumers strongly preferred home country of origin, i.e. US wines. Men and women both ranked US wines first, followed by

Variable	Mean – men	SD men	Mean – women	SD women	t-value	Significance level
<i>Information search</i>						
Server, sommelier	5.57	1.45	5.83	1.35	– 3.364	0.001
Store personnel	5.34	1.42	5.57	1.53	– 2.807	0.005
Label	5.27	1.62	5.42	1.49	– 1.754	0.080
Shelf tag	4.82	1.57	5.24	1.59	– 0.4697	0.000
Friends	4.56	1.72	5.08	1.63	– 5.568	0.000
Menu	4.34	1.66	4.90	1.53	– 6.288	0.000
Reviews	4.89	1.71	4.85	1.75	0.506	0.613
Books	4.83	1.79	4.21	1.86	6.006	0.000
<i>Coping mechanism</i>						
Region	5.28	1.22	5.19	1.27	1.300	0.194
Medals	4.05	1.62	4.68	1.51	– 7.154	0.000
Price	4.21	1.49	4.58	1.46	– 4.461	0.000
Buy the same	4.02	1.61	4.50	1.53	– 5.475	0.000
Artwork	2.69	1.56	3.38	1.70	– 7.485	0.000
Random	2.40	1.53	3.13	1.74	– 7.873	0.000
Do not buy	1.98	1.45	1.65	1.23	4.441	0.000
Sources reviewed	5.31	8.09	3.44	3.17	6.052	0.000
Screw caps bought	2.09	4.27	1.05	2.24	5.972	0.000
How often drink	1.70	0.671	1.93	0.664	– 6.327	0.000
Notes: Based on a sample of 1,374 US wine drinkers: 497 males and 877 females						

Table II.
A listing of the two
categories of questions
and the responses

Australia, South America and France. Women did show a significantly stronger preference for South American wines than men (mean – men = 4.51, SD = 1.33, mean – women = 4.82, SD = 1.34, $p = 0.000$).

Packaging is a very important clue for many shoppers when trying to assess the quality of a wine. It can be used as a proxy for quality when the wine cannot be trialed personally. A controversial aspect of packaging is the closure. Both genders clearly preferred the natural cork. Synthetic closures followed and screw caps were viewed somewhat negatively, finishing last. Interestingly, women showed a significantly stronger preference for natural cork than men (mean – men = 5.37, SD = 1.43, mean – women = 5.67, SD = 1.35, $p = 0.000$). On the other side of the coin, women showed a significantly more negative attitude toward the screw cap than men, who were basically neutral on the issue (mean – men = 3.97, SD = 1.75, mean – women = 3.20, SD = 1.79, $p = 0.000$).

Regarding price, both groups ranked the \$10.00 to \$14.99 price category the highest. A significant difference was shown in that men displayed a stronger preference for the most expensive (\$25.00 and up) price category (mean – men = 4.37, SD = 1.78, mean – women = 3.90, SD = 1.66, $p = 0.000$). Women, on the other hand, showed a stronger preference than men for the \$10.00 to \$14.99 wines (mean – men = 5.43, SD = 1.40, mean – women = 5.82, SD = 1.20, $p = 0.000$) women also showed a stronger, but not

significant, preference for the \$2.00 to \$9.99 price category (mean – men = 4.14, SD = 1.96, mean – women = 4.34, SD = 1.94, $p = 0.070$).

When asked about preferences based on the size of the winery, men showed a stronger preference for small wineries (mean – men = 5.62, mean – women = 5.34, $p = 0.000$). Women, on the other hand, exhibited a statistically stronger preference for national (mean – men = 4.38, mean – women = 4.55, $p = 0.027$) and international wineries than men (mean – men = 3.54, mean – women = 3.80, $p = 0.001$).

The next area of research concerned the information search habits of men and women. As shown in Tables II and III, women showed a significantly stronger preference for acquiring on the spot information, including asking questions of the sommelier and reading the menu in restaurants as well as asking store personnel, reading labels, and reading shelf tags in stores. Men showed a significantly stronger tendency to read books about wine. This tendency of searching for information away from the point of purchase was also evident when we looked at the number of information sources reviewed. The mean for men was 5.31 sources reviewed and the mean for women was significantly lower at 3.44 sources reviewed ($p = 0.000$).

When sufficient information cannot be obtained, there was a clear difference in the coping mechanisms of men and women. While the most popular coping mechanism for both was to rely on region of origin, women showed a significantly stronger tendency to make a decision based upon secondary criteria such as medals won, price, buying the usual brand, buying based upon artwork and just randomly choosing a bottle (see Table IV). Although it was the least preferred choice of both sexes, men felt less negative about walking away without buying a bottle of wine.

Information search	Mean – men	SD	Mean – women	SD	Significance level
Server, sommelier	5.57	1.45	5.83	1.35	0.001
Store personnel	5.34	1.42	5.57	1.53	0.005
Label	5.27	1.62	5.42	1.49	0.080
Shelf tag	4.82	1.57	5.24	1.59	0.000
Friends	4.56	1.72	5.08	1.63	0.000
Menu	4.34	1.66	4.90	1.53	0.000
Reviews	4.89	1.71	4.85	1.75	0.613
Books	4.83	1.79	4.21	1.86	0.000
Sources reviewed	5.31	8.09	3.44	3.17	0.000

Table III.
The information search
habits of men and women

Coping mechanism	Mean – men	SD	Mean – women	SD	Significance level
Region	5.28	1.22	5.19	1.27	0.194
Medals	4.05	1.62	4.68	1.51	0.000
Price	4.21	1.49	4.58	1.46	0.000
Always buy	4.02	1.61	4.50	1.53	0.000
Artwork	2.69	1.56	3.38	1.70	0.000
Random	2.40	1.53	3.13	1.74	0.000
Do not buy	1.98	1.45	1.65	1.23	0.000

Table IV.
The coping mechanisms

Lessons learned

To overcome the social risk, we suggest that wine marketers need to focus on the value and image barriers associated with packaging. In order to reduce the likelihood of making a bad purchase decision, consumers employ risk reduction strategies (Mitchell and Greatedorex, 1988). A variety of strategies have been enumerated in previous research (Spawton, 1991b), including the use of extrinsic cues such as pricing and packaging. Since objective information is often not available, consumers rely on subjective information, which is also known as perceived quality. Ram and Sheth (1989) suggest improving the product's positioning by creating a unique image. One way of increasing perceived value is by introducing unique packaging on wines to send a signal of quality.

It is also important for wine marketers to promote the quality advantages of recent innovations such as screw caps and bag-in-box. The results of a recent international survey showed that Australians and New Zealanders do not find the tradition of corks (the "pop" and the ceremonial presentation) as important as do Americans (Atkin *et al.*, 2006). This indicates that resistance relating to tradition and ritual can be overcome if the relative advantages of such innovations are promoted to the consumer. The same study found that men are more likely to be adopters of screw caps compared to women, so marketing campaigns may profit by showing how innovative packaging can fit into women's values and lifestyle. One possible way of doing this is to develop wine cellar door activities for women. A "girl's night out" program will allow women to feel comfortable discussing wine amongst themselves and will also allow the winery to obtain value feedback regarding women's preferences.

This information is important because wineries need to know how to make wine more accessible to the public. As new innovations are introduced, the right people need to be reached in order to achieve success. For example, a recent examination of the early adopters in the US showed that educating consumers about screw cap advantages is important. Early adopters are more likely to discuss wine with others and review new material about wine. By directing their marketing efforts to the right target segment, wineries can enhance their chances of success with new product developments. Another example is that men are less likely to buy the same wine than women. This may indicate that marketers should appeal to consistency for the female market while a new experience may be more appealing to men. Additionally, men's stronger preference for expensive (\$25.00 and up) as opposed to women's stronger preference for medium priced wine (\$10.00 to \$14.99) could also form the basis for differing marketing emphases.

Conclusion

This paper investigates the impact of the consumer's gender on buying decisions and responses to the wine purchase situation. A variety of individual consumer preferences were researched, focusing especially on product attributes, information search, and coping mechanisms. The results show that these consumer preferences can serve as markers in developing and targeting persuasive messages to attract specific consumer groups. This will help marketers to develop strategies to increase sales.

Consumer perceptions of price, quality, and value are considered to be pivotal determinants of product choice. The challenge for marketers will be how to reach women consumers with information about wines in a manner that is relevant to their

busy lifestyles. Well informed restaurant and store personnel appear to be critical factors in a brand's success. Labels and shelf tags are important sources of information in the retail setting and should be designed to appeal to women's tastes for style, color, food pairings, and even humor.

More general and public research is needed to better understand how, for example, packaging impacts the purchase decision (Thomas, 2000). Packaging is pivotal to both the delivery and acceptance of a wide range of products. Packaging is important for technical and functional reasons, but also for aesthetics and emotion. It represents the last chance to communicate with and influence the consumer. In addition, why do women have a stronger preference for national and international wine brands? Does it relate to availability at the retail level?

Respondents were obtained in the US by sending e-mails to the customer lists provided by wine-related groups such as the Wine Brats and the Winex Wine Club. Membership in these types of organizations suggest the sample was a group with a high level of involvement with wine. Therefore, as with many internet-administered surveys, a certain type of wine consumer may not have been sampled. For example, consumers who are not necessarily comfortable with using the internet would not have had an opportunity to participate in this study. Consumers who are less involved in wine organizations and wine web pages also would not have been sampled. However, a response rate of 1691 should provide enough reliable data for wine marketers that supports the premise that there are significant gender differences in wine decision-making methods and wine preferences.

The results of this study can be useful for industry in general as a means for gathering knowledge about the timing of a product launch of a discontinuous innovation, for evaluating ways to speed the takeoff of new products, and for understanding how gender may affect the acceptance of products and decision-making criteria. Marketing managers in the US have long been concerned with how to launch products most effectively and how to reach consumers with information. This research demonstrates how perceptions of product attributes differ for various genders. The differences in these perceptions could help to predict likely communications problems and overcome them. Each product category will likely need research to understand the role of gender in getting new products into the marketplace and how to influence retail buyers, especially women. A better understanding of how consumers choose products will lead to a better framework on which to base decisions on pricing, packaging, and distribution.

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